



Second Life

Second Life is a very popular free environment for making machinima. Head over to www.secondlife.com

Speedruns

Intrigued by the concept of speedruns? Check out some of the best over at speedruns.net

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Ever since computers became personal, a strange kind of ethic has evolved in those who push the limits of what their machines and applications can do. A number of sub-cultures have evolved around computers, where hardware and software are used for purposes that they were not designed for. The scope of such experimentation is wide, ranging from bending pins on a circuit board for creating music to writing haiku in languages meant for coding. The internet allowed for such efforts to spread, eventually allowing a wide range of technology related art forms to emerge. Most of these communities require extensive knowledge and experience in one, or more fields of computing. Consequently, it is difficult for outsiders to appreciate the brilliance of the community's efforts. It takes a lot of time and effort before newcomers are accepted. The community around Machinima is one notable exception. Machinima is easy to grasp, but tough to master. However, anyone with a computer and a decent graphics solution can jump right in.

Some of the early games that were released had an option to record gameplay. This was a feature in the game engine itself, that tracked the movement of the player through the game, and recorded sequence of movements. Such a recording was called a "demo". A demo file consisted basically of a sequence of keypresses with a time map, that could be played back on the same engine used to create it. Demo files were shared around to display extra ordinary skill, show secret areas or as walkthroughs for particular games and levels. Such demos are still shared around the internet, particularly for *Warcraft 3* and games derived from the *Quake* series. Parallel to this development, was the emergence of speedruns. This was a community that thrived on completing games and particular levels in the lowest time possible, and

sharing their achievements. Now, speedruns were accomplished on a variety of platforms, and even if saving demos was an option on these platforms, sharing them over the internet was not an option as those who wished to play back the speedruns had to have the same platform. This was a problem with some demos as

well, as games with a particular patch could not play back demos of versions that did not have the particular patch. The increase in bandwidth, and developments in video compression technology, considerably reduced the advantage that demos had over video recordings of gameplay.

At this crucial juncture in 1996, the Rangers clan created waves in the *Quake* community with a new kind of demo. Demos usually had players jumping around and rocketing the guts out of other players, the *Diary of a Camper* had the same things – but with a storyline to it. This was the first film to embrace Machinima techniques, but back then there were not too many game engines that allowed people to modify the game environments with the same degree of control as the *Quake* engine, so most early machnima works were on the *Quake* engine only. These were called *Quake* movies, and grew so much that there were even *Quake* movie Oscar awards. Tools were written for recording and non-linear editing of these films, paving the way for Machinima.

By the year 2000, the community had started experimenting with other game engines and machinima.com was launched. Machinima is a portmanteau of "Machine" and "Cinema", which means machine generated cinema. The word sounds a lot like animation too, and those who practice Machinima are called Machinimators. At the heart of Machinima is a brilliant idea that fundamentally changed the approach for animation production. Computer generated images were in themselves a difficult operation. Lights, environments and characters had to be rendered, which was a time consuming process. Game environments on the other hand, rendered all these in real time, drastically reducing the amount of system resources used in creating animated sequences.

A traditional animation production process involved a lot of steps. First, characters had to be designed, with internal and external touches added.

Animation using game engines

